

Predicting turning points of an economic cycle

預測經濟週期轉折點

The aforementioned countercyclical strategies are based on an assumption that business executives know when the peak will be and can therefore take action in advance. But how do you know the timing of these peaks? It is unrealistic for business executives to predict the exact date of a peak or a trough. However, statistics on the duration of previous cycles may provide some clues. The National Bureau of Economic Research (NBER), a well-known economic research institute in the US, offers just these statistics. NBER has a Business Cycle Dating Committee to determine business cycles in the US. In 2010 the committee confirmed June 2009 as the trough of the economic downturn following the crisis of 2008 by considering a number of economic indicators. NBER has also identified all economic peaks and troughs in the US since 1857. The following table shows those peaks and troughs after 1950 (the post-war period).

上述逆週期策略建基於這樣一個假設：企業管理人知道高峰何時出現，因此可提前採取行動。然而，如何能知道高峰的時機呢？要企業管理人準確預測高峰或低谷的確切日期，無疑是癡人說夢。然而，過往經濟週期的長短，可能會提供一些線索。享負盛名的美國全國經濟研究所，正為我們提供了這些統計數據。美國全國經濟研究所設有商業週期定期委員會，專責分析美國的商業週期。2010年時，委員會考慮過一些列經濟指標後，確認2009年6月乃2008年金融危機後的低谷。它亦列出美國自1857年起的所有經濟高峰和低谷。以下列表列舉出1950年（戰後時期）的高峰和低谷。

